perpetuity from villages on that land. This practice produced its own collateral damage: a slow rot that undermined the monasteries. As they gained economic self-sufficiency, they did so at the cost of forgetting their central mission of alleviating suffering in the world. They grew ‘largely divorced from day-to-day interaction with the laity, and instead became landlords over growing monastic properties’.[25] They isolated themselves and retreated into private courtyards, often by erecting physical barriers. Their thick boundary walls and gated living became more than just metaphors for self-absorbed seclusion.



Figure 8. A large room in a monastery, perhaps a senior teacher’s

This was in fact a profound shift from the earliest monasteries, where the laity visited temples that were adjacent to the monks’ residential quarters—as in the Dalai Lama’s complex in Dharamshala today. This fostered trust, community and mutual dependence— the monks provided worship and other valued services, especially at major Buddhist pilgrimage sites where the early monasteries were located and in return received alms that sustained them. Monks balanced their individualistic quests with